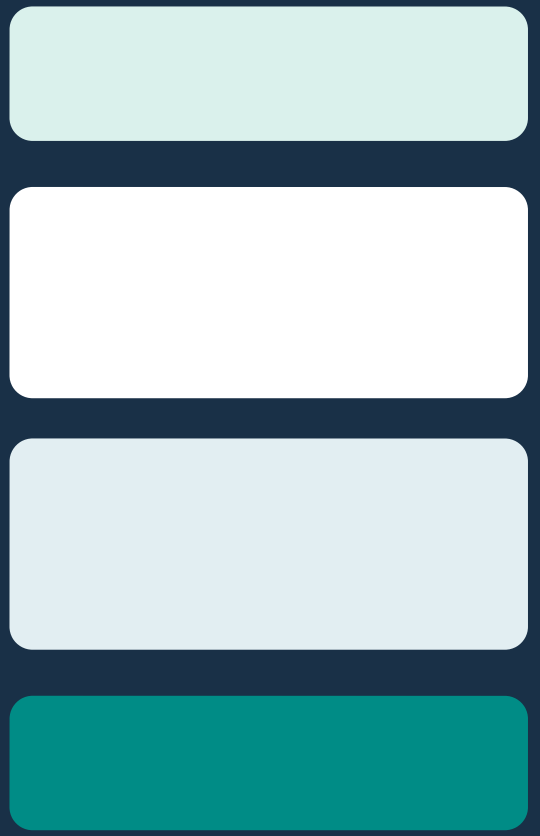
ESSENTIAL LECTURE 03

Planning and Organising a Publication

From a clear purpose and audience to a simple, readable page.



By the end of this lecture...

You should be able to plan an A4 hand-out before opening a design application.

01 Define purpose and audience

Explain why the publication is needed and identify who will read it.

02 Choose the key content

Select a main message, supporting points and one clear reader action.

03 Sketch a basic layout

Draw a thumbnail showing the heading, image, content, margin and footer.

04 Explain your choices

Describe how hierarchy, alignment and spacing help the reader.

How Lecture 3 connects to your previous learning

Good layouts depend on the visual communication principles you already know.

Lecture 1: Visual communication

A strong publication makes the main message easy to notice. Contrast, alignment and proximity help organise the page.

Lecture 2: Text and graphics

Readable type, suitable images and restrained colour help the audience understand the message.

Lecture 3: Planning

Now decide the message and reading order before choosing the fonts, colours and software.

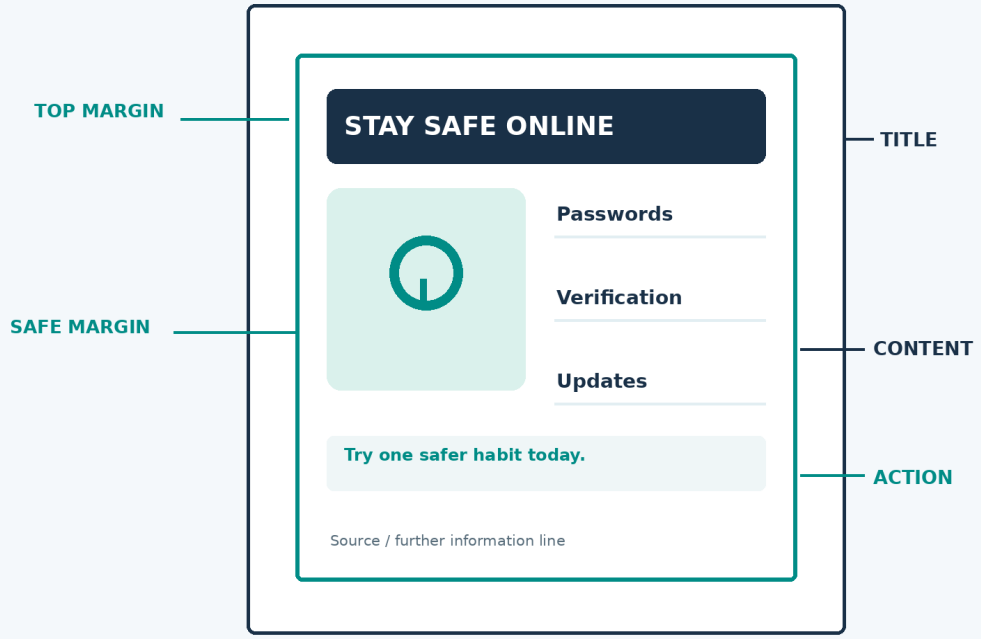
Planning is the bridge between an idea and a finished document.

Our running project: a one-page learning hand-out

This fictional brief will continue through Photoshop, Illustrator and InDesign exercises.

Tumaini Community Learning Centre

Create an A4 hand-out titled “Stay Safe Online” for first-year students. It should explain basic online safety habits in plain language and suggest one action readers can take today.



The organisation and assignment details are fictional classroom examples.

Plan first. Design second. Produce last.

A publication is easier to revise when its purpose and content are settled early.

1

PURPOSE

Why is this publication needed?

2

AUDIENCE

Who will read or use it?

3

CONTENT

What must readers learn?

4

LAYOUT

Where should each element go?

Start with the reader’s need—not with decorative fonts or software effects.

The purpose is what the publication must achieve

Purpose describes the intended result of communication, not simply the document format.

Weak statement

“We are making an A4 hand-out.” This identifies a format, but it does not explain what readers should learn or do.

Better statement

“We want first-year students to recognise three online safety habits and apply at least one today.” This gives the design a clear goal.

A useful purpose can often be written as: “After reading, the audience should be able to…”

The audience shapes every design decision

A suitable publication considers readers' knowledge, language, context and available devices.

What do they already know?

Avoid unexplained technical words when readers are beginners.

Where will they read it?

A printed A4 sheet needs readable text at normal viewing distance.

What matters to them?

Lead with practical benefits and familiar examples.

What action can they take?

Use a short, realistic instruction rather than vague advice.

One topic, two different audiences

The same subject needs different explanations for different readers.

First-year diploma students

Headline: “5 simple ways to protect your accounts.” Explain strong passwords, verification and suspicious links with short examples.

Experienced IT technicians

Headline: “Account security checklist.” Technical detail and policies may be appropriate because readers already know basic terms.

Our assignment is aimed at the first group, so plain language is more important than jargon.

Scope prevents a one-page document becoming overcrowded

Scope sets boundaries on what the publication will and will not include.

Inside the scope

A concise title, three to five safety tips, one helpful graphic and one clear action to try.

Outside the scope

A full cybersecurity syllabus, complicated technical diagrams or long explanations of every threat.

Short publications become stronger when unnecessary content is deliberately removed.

A design brief records decisions before layout begins

A brief is a short description of what must be made, for whom and for what purpose.

A practical five-point brief

1. Product: one-page A4 hand-out.
2. Audience: new college students.
3. Purpose: encourage safer online habits.
4. Main message: small steps reduce risk.
5. Delivery: print and digital PDF.

Why write it?

A brief helps the designer avoid wasting time on unsuitable details. It also gives the client or tutor a simple basis for feedback before the final artwork is made.

Five questions to ask before you design

These questions make the brief practical rather than bureaucratic.

WHO?	Who needs this information?
WHY?	What should change after reading?
WHAT?	Which message and facts are essential?
WHERE?	Will it be printed, shared on screen or both?
HOW?	What makes the information easy to find?

Good content is selected, not collected indiscriminately

Include only details that support the purpose and the audience’s immediate needs.

Must know

A clear title; the main safety recommendation; the most useful examples; a simple reader action.

Helpful if space allows

A small icon or illustration; a short reminder; one trustworthy source line.

Leave for extended reading

Long background histories, technical definitions and unrelated warnings.

A one-page hand-out is not a shortened textbook chapter: it should prioritise action.

Content hierarchy decides what readers encounter first

A hierarchy separates the main message from supporting explanations and optional detail.



Use heading size, position, spacing and contrast to communicate levels of importance.

A content outline is the skeleton of your page

Arrange messages in a logical reading order before deciding colours or exact positions.

1 Headline

Stay Safe Online

2 Short introduction

Your accounts and data deserve simple protection.

3 Three habits

Use strong passwords; turn on verification; check links.

4 Action

Choose one habit and practise it today.

5 Source line

Provide a credible source or course reference.

A content map links each message to a place on the page

It helps prevent an attractive design from losing important information.

TOP	Main heading and introductory sentence
MIDDLE LEFT	Simple icon or illustration
MIDDLE RIGHT	Three to five short safety habits
BOTTOM	Action line, source and contact if needed

The map records the location and purpose of each element—not finished artwork.

A mind map can help you gather ideas quickly

Begin with a topic in the middle, then add possible points around it. Edit afterwards.

STRONG PASSWORDS

TWO-STEP CHECKS

STAY SAFE ONLINE

CHECK LINKS

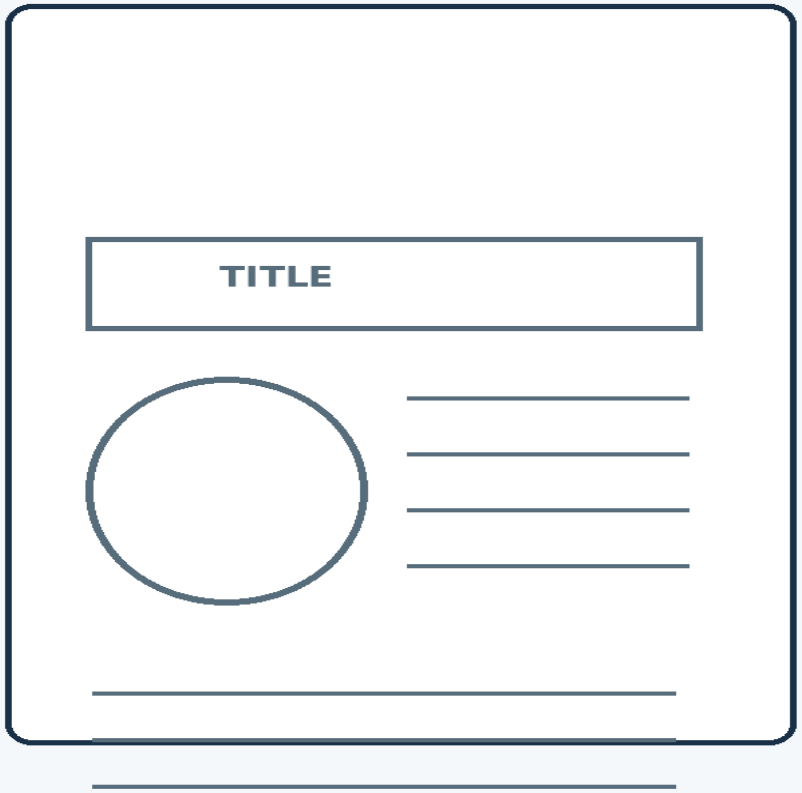
UPDATE DEVICES

A mind map is a tool for generating ideas; it is not the final page layout.

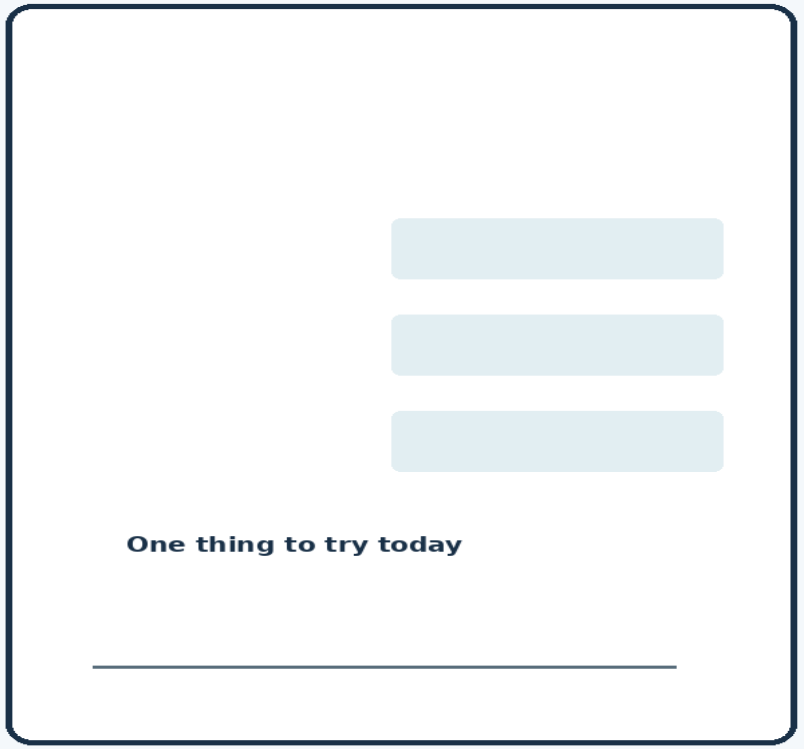
A thumbnail sketch is a very small page plan

A quick sketch lets you test positions and balance without committing to the final design.

ROUGH THUMBNAIL



MORE ORDERED WIREFRAME



Boxes and lines are enough. Attractive drawing is not required at this stage.

A wireframe shows the structure more clearly

It represents the approximate size and placement of text, graphics and white space.

Thumbnail sketch

A rough early idea, often drawn quickly by hand. Several thumbnails can be compared before choosing a direction.

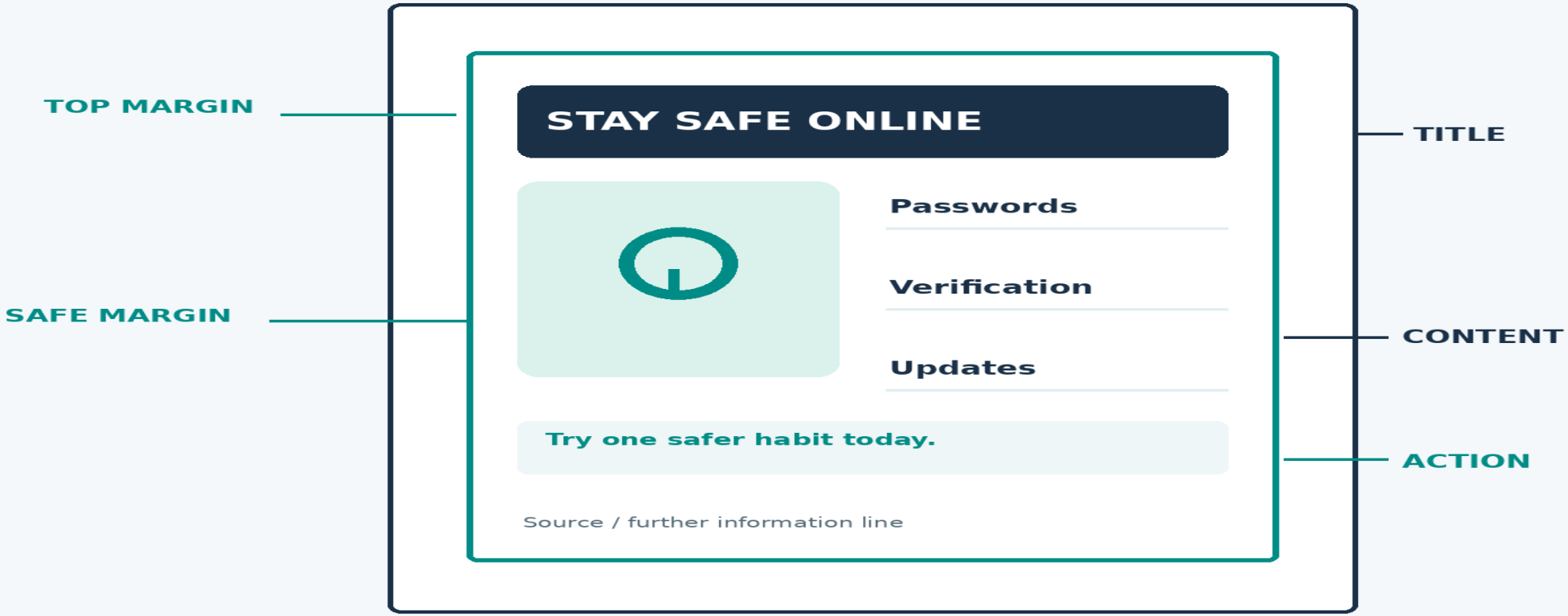
Wireframe

A more deliberate structure with areas reserved for the title, content, illustrations and footer. Exact colours are not yet necessary.

Both are planning tools; neither is the finished publication.

A basic A4 layout needs clear zones

Decide where the heading, image, core content and action line will fit.



A clean reading path is usually more valuable than complex visual effects.

Margins keep important content away from the edge

A margin is the space between the edge of a page and the main content area.

Why margins matter

Margins help text breathe and reduce the risk of cropping or crowding. Consistent edges also make different parts of the page feel connected.

Simple starting rule

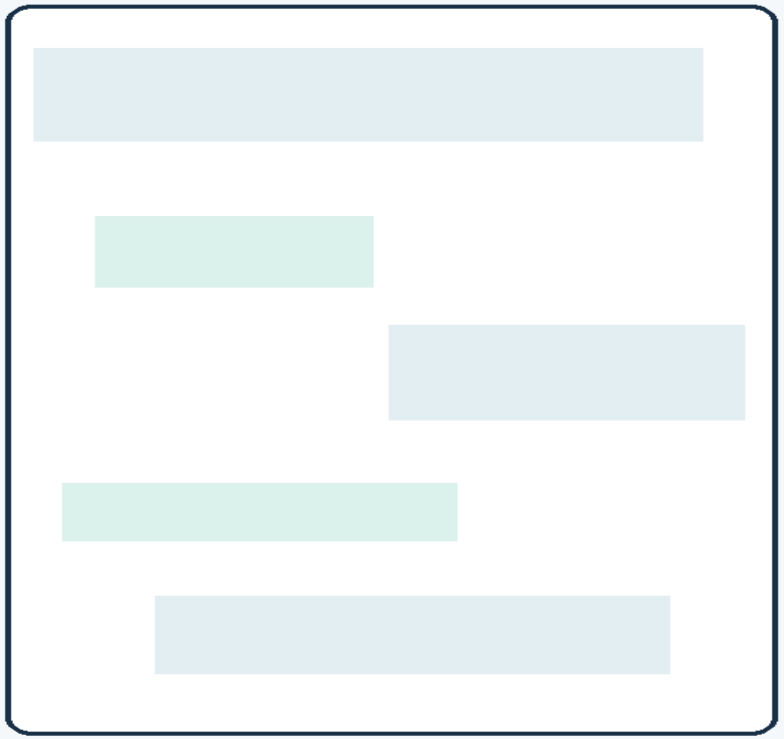
For an A4 classroom hand-out, begin with approximately 15–20 mm of space around the main content, then adjust for the page and printer.

A margin is a design choice, not the same thing as bleed for commercial printing.

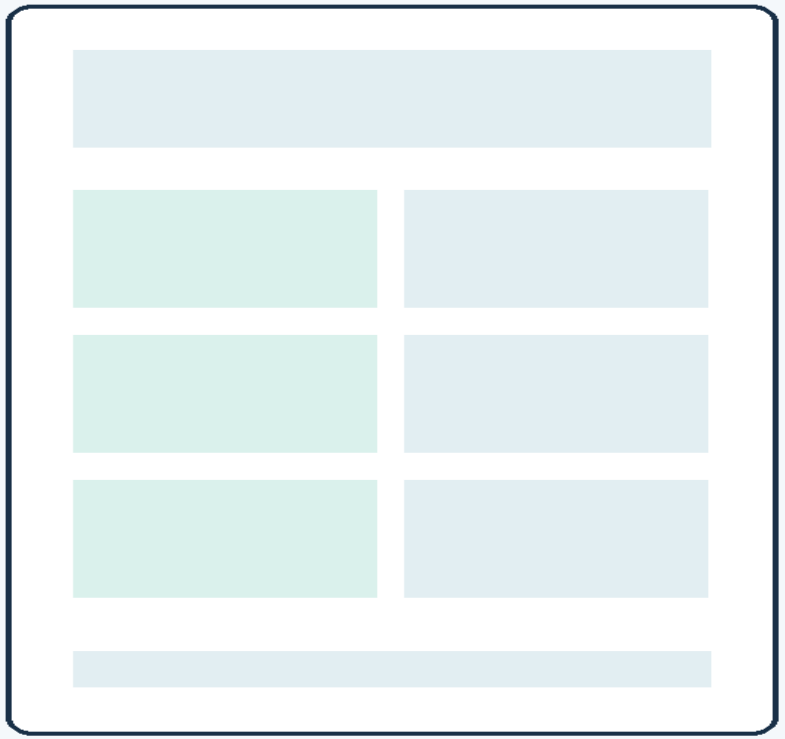
A grid makes alignment easier

A grid is an underlying arrangement of columns and spaces that helps organise the page.

NO CLEAR GUIDES



SIMPLE TWO-COLUMN GRID



For a beginner hand-out, a simple single-column or two-column grid is enough.

Use alignment and proximity to improve the sketch

Good planning already applies the visual communication skills from Lecture 1.

Alignment

Place related items along shared vertical or horizontal lines. Random positions make a page feel unstable and harder to scan.

Proximity

Keep headings near the text they introduce. Separate unrelated sections so readers can recognise groups quickly.

The best grid is one that improves reading, not one that adds unnecessary complexity.

Whitespace is part of the design

Blank space gives important ideas room to stand out and helps readers see where one section ends.

Crowded page

Every space is filled with text, unrelated icons or decoration. Readers have few visual clues about what matters most.

Clear page

The title, key points and action have breathing room. Related items form visible groups, and the page feels easier to scan.

Leaving space empty is not wasting space when it improves understanding.

Ask whether every element earns its place

A planning check can save more time than a late redesign.

Heading

Can the reader identify the topic immediately?

Image

Does it explain something or merely decorate the page?

Body text

Is the essential message concise and correctly grouped?

Action line

Does the reader know what to do next?

Plan for the format in which the page will be used

Publication format influences page size, image clarity and how the audience reads.

Printed A4 hand-out

Keep the page within reliable print margins; use readable type and artwork that remains clear when printed.

Digital PDF

Check page readability on a small screen, preserve text and ensure any links are functional.

Our project will first use A4 as the master page and may later be exported as a PDF.

Feedback is more useful before final production

Show the brief and rough layout to someone who resembles the intended reader.

Ask specific questions

“What did you read first?” “Which advice was difficult?” “What action would you take?” These questions reveal problems you can fix.

Make one thoughtful revision

If readers miss the key action, make it easier to find. If a term is unfamiliar, rewrite it rather than adding a longer paragraph.

Feedback is evidence about the design—not a vote on a favourite colour.

The minimum planning sequence for this course

You can complete this process with pencil and paper before using any software.

1. Write

Purpose and audience

2. Select

Main message and essential facts

3. Arrange

A4 thumbnail with margins and zones

4. Check

Reading order and one reader action

Class activity: write a five-line publication brief

Use the fictional Tumaini hand-out assignment described earlier.

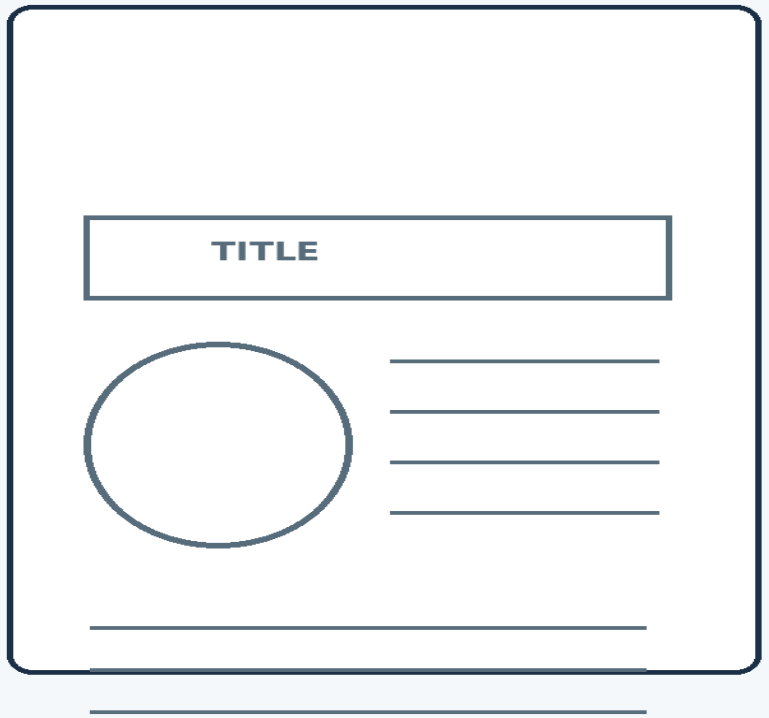
Complete these five lines

1. The publication I will create is …
2. My intended readers are …
3. After reading, they should …
4. Three essential points to include are …
5. The document will be delivered as …

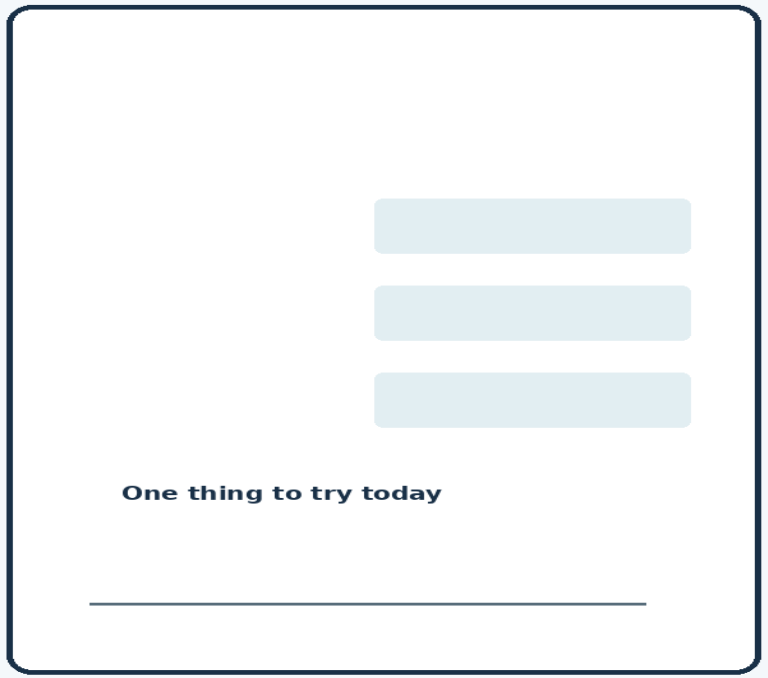
Class activity: sketch the page in five minutes

Keep the drawing simple. Show the information, not artistic talent.

ROUGH THUMBNAIL



MORE ORDERED WIREFRAME



Label the heading, image/icon, three tips, action line and source.

Before submitting: five quality checks

Use these questions to test the first draft of your one-page hand-out.

1. Is the audience clear?
2. Is one main message unmistakable?
3. Does every key fact have a place?
4. Are margins, alignment and spacing consistent?
5. Is there one realistic action for the reader?

Example of a clear planning decision

Notice how the five lines support each other rather than describing different projects.

Tumaini — Stay Safe Online

Format: A4, one-page educational hand-out.
Audience: first-year diploma students who are new to online safety.
Purpose: help readers identify simple account-protection habits.
Content: strong passwords, two-step verification, suspicious links.
Action: choose one security setting to improve today.

Four planning mistakes to avoid

Most beginner layout problems start before the software is opened.

Too much content

Trying to fit every fact on a single A4 page.

No clear audience

Using technical language that beginners may not understand.

Decoration first

Choosing colours and fonts before deciding what matters.

Skipping the sketch

Building directly in software and repeatedly moving elements.

Tutorial and practical follow-up

These tasks develop the same skills without adding new theory to memorise.

Tutorial (paper)

Discuss the purpose and audience in pairs. Compare two thumbnail sketches and explain which is easier to understand.

Practical (paper or computer)

Create your own A4 wireframe and content outline. Add labels for the title, graphic, key points, action and source.

Submit a brief and an annotated sketch; a polished digital publication is not yet required.

Five ideas to remember

These are the concepts you should recognise and explain without notes.

Purpose

The change the document should produce.

Audience

The people for whom the message is intended.

Brief

A short record of design requirements.

Hierarchy

The order in which content receives attention.

Wireframe

A plan showing where page elements belong.

Check your understanding before CAT 1

Use the review questions to strengthen your understanding of the first three lectures.

Review questions

1. What distinguishes a document purpose from its format?
2. Give two reasons why the target audience affects layout decisions.
3. Explain how hierarchy and margins improve an A4 hand-out.
4. List the five elements of a useful design brief.
5. Sketch and label a simple one-page publication.

Review the essential concepts of visual communication, graphics and planning.